
FERTILITY

Birth is a Mess

FEATURE · GOTHIC HORROR · ORIGINAL SCREENPLAY

DIRECTOR'S VISION

Written and Directed by Bennet De Brabandere

THE FILM



Gregory Crewdson, *Beneath the Roses*.

A Husband and Wife

A Surrogate

A Child

A Bloodline

They are coming for the baby

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

FERTILITY: A horror mystery born of dread and fate.

A couple who cannot have a child are offered a surrogate. She is young, beautiful, kind, and she carries an ancient bloodline that is coming for the baby. Everything that should be safe, the best clinic, a contract, a healthy surrogate. What's revealed is what was there the whole time, waiting for the seed to take.

A simple want, for a family of their own pushes everyone forward. That's how the bloodline works: a woman offers herself, and by offering herself she takes everything. The surrogate carrying Roman's child is the woman who once carried Roman. Together they will be born again. It's impossible. And yet. There's fate in blood.

At the centre is a man who built his whole life on the belief that he chose his path. FERTILITY is the story of Roman learning that his future was chosen before he was born. That legacy and family are already his and it requires a terrible choice. His wife Shauna refuses to see what she already knows, that what she wants more than anything has already escaped her. They wanted a child and their true desires are revealed.

This is a film in the lineage of *Rosemary's Baby*, *Dead Ringers*, and *Hereditary*. When the house burns, the bloodline lives on.

THE CLINIC

The Fertility Clinic

This is where Roman and Shauna go to buy a future: the most legitimate room in the film, elite and immaculate and reassuring. It is also where the bloodline performs its rite. The surrogacy is real medicine and an ancient ceremony at once, and the film never lets you pull them apart. The silver instrument is for insemination and sacrament. Behind the one-way glass, conception is watched like a service. Nothing in the room says horror. All of it is.



The rite the clinic is built to hide. Three women, a blade, sacred violence done as close, careful work. (Caravaggio, *Judith Beheading Holofernes*.)



Surgical register. (*Dead Ringers*.)



See what emerges from the dark.

THE LOOK · PALETTE & THE UNCANNY

Dread has a Cool Palette Warmth is a Bloody Event

Blue-hour atmosphere, slate, silver-green, diffused grey. Warmth never washes a room. It exists only as a source you can point at. A lamp in the window. A flesh tone. A fire.



Gregory Crewdson, *Beneath the Roses*. The palette contract in a single frame. Cool slate street, cool sky, cool brick. Count the warm sources: the amber signal, the yellow signal, the storefront bulbs. Three. That is the correct number.



Crewdson, *Cathedral of the Pines*. Nothing in the composition says horror. And yet there is dread in the arrangement.

The uncanny is one displaced element

Every frame is built to read correct, a country house on a perfect evening, with a single element precisely inexplicably wrong. This is the governing mechanic.

Captured on 35mm film, with vintage glass, modern lighting, in-camera effects.

THE UNCANNY FAMILIAR

The Familiar Turned Quietly Wrong

The German word for the uncanny is *unheimlich*: literally unhomely, the home made strange. It is the engine of the film. A sense it's not right. A photograph a character cannot unsee.

FERTILITY turns on a Polaroid, dated decades before it should exist, an image that proves the present was always a repetition. The horror is never announced. It is recognised, slowly, as something the audience already knew.



The 1983 Polaroid register. The pregnant body on a red sofa, shot like a snapshot found in a drawer. (Nan Goldin, *Geno on my sofa*, 1994.)



Francesca Woodman, Roma, 1977–78. The blurred, mortal snapshot: youth dissolving into a bare room, half-here and half-gone. The texture of the film's 1983 Polaroid.

THE LEAD

A Principled Man



James Stewart, in Hitchcock's cool register. Sincere, self-made, certain he is choosing well. The register the role is written in.

Roman is the film's moral centre: a principled man who meets evil couched in the most genuine desire to do right, by his wife, for the family they have not been able to make. Every loving choice tightens the trap.

He is decent in the register of James Stewart: sure of his own goodness, earnest in his intentions, in his desire for a family. That is exactly what the bloodline requires. The role asks its lead to be sincere in his intentions, so that the audience goes all the way with him.

HIS WIFE



The register for Shauna: elegant, composed, determined.

Refuses to See What She Knows

Shauna wants two things: a baby, and her husband. She refuses to see what she already knows. Her body performs a phantom pregnancy. She reduces the unimaginable to something survivable.

Then the baby will not feed from her. Motherhood collapses at its most primal. Her instinct finally surfaces: 'I knew it.' She demands the truth in a lawyer's language, and leaves. If she returns, it's to face the fire and the truth.

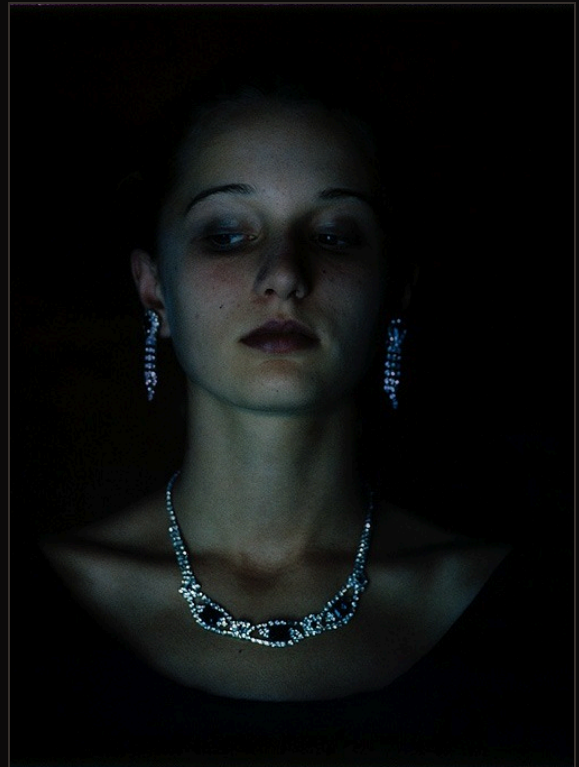
THE SURROGATE

Youth Beauty Fertile

Leah is the offering: young, luminous, barefoot, chosen for a body that works. The audience can see the appeal and yet sense that something is amiss. She hums to the baby through her own skin. That is the trap, and it is laid with beauty and warmth.



Young, blonde, carrying: beautiful before she is frightening.



Bill Henson, *Paris Opera Project*. The same youth, surfacing from the dark, adorned.

THE WOMEN



Diane Arbus, a performer in her dressing room.
Exposed, enthroned, in complete command of the gaze aimed at her. The template for Chani.

Ascension by Submission

The women of FERTILITY hold power precisely by seeming to give themselves away. Chani, the surrogate, the mother: each rules through display, through tenderness, through the pose of service.

The men believe they are choosing. The women have already arranged the room. It is the pin-up's oldest trick, taken seriously as a theology: the body offered is the body in command.

THE SET-PIECES

Iconic Scenes

01 · THE INSEMINATION

The procedure plays as a miracle and a rite at once. Hope and dread in one frame, and both are telling the truth.

02 · THE WOMB, FROM THE INSIDE

At the midpoint the camera goes inside the surrogate: the child present at its own making. Not a dream or diversion. The truth is gestating as well.

03 · THE RITE'S OWN RULES, TURNED INTO A WEAPON

The ceremony has one requirement it cannot proceed without. Roman is the first to understand that its rules can be used against it. He does not fight the rite. He holds it hostage.

04 · THE MIS-STRIKE

The coven never overpowers Roman. It seduces him. A vision of milk and mother rises at the instant the blade is raised, a small gesture planted an hour earlier fires under the spell, and the knife comes down on the wrong body. Theme turned into muscle memory.

05 · THE REVELATION

A rational man runs out of rational explanations. What's impossible is true.

06 · THE MOLT

The house burns and the bloodline does not. In the ash an old woman's shell splits, a new surrogate steps out into the morning.



The weight of a bloodline. (Rembrandt.)



The mother that cannot be. (Leonardo.)



The house that burns.

THE PROMISE

Birth and death, good and evil,
one unyielding churn.
It was turning long before this family.
It will be turning long after.
Bloodlines don't die. They shed their skin.

FERTILITY

Bennet De Brabandere · bdb@merc3.com